

Style Guide & Design Rationale

Discovering Your Narrative Voice — Visual & Interaction Standards

This documents the visual and interaction language already established in the original module and explains why each choice works for this audience — not a new design system, but an audit of the existing one, with rationale attached so future screens (including the ones proposed in the Storyboard) stay consistent rather than arbitrary.

Why This Document Exists

Most instructional design programs — mine included — teach adult learning theory, content architecture, and assessment design as the core of the discipline, and treat visual and interaction design as someone else's job: a developer's task, applied after the instructional logic is already finished. That division doesn't hold up under scrutiny. A learner's sense of safety, trust, and willingness to make a visible mistake is shaped by what a screen looks and feels like before they read a single word of content on it — which makes aesthetic and interaction choices instructional decisions, not cosmetic ones layered on top.

This isn't a fringe position — it's the premise behind Learning Experience Design (LXD), a growing discipline that treats the learner's felt experience of a product, not just its information architecture, as a first-class design concern. Most ID training hasn't caught up to it yet. This document treats the module's visual choices with the same rigor as its content choices for that reason: the warm background over a clinical one, green over red, a literal progress count over an abstract bar — each is defended on instructional grounds in this document, not aesthetic ones, because in a module built for an audience this sensitive to institutional framing, that's what they actually are.

In practice this means: even on a platform where the visual system is already decided by someone else, the instructional designer's job doesn't stop at content. Understanding why a given visual or interaction choice helps or harms a specific learner is part of the design work, not a courtesy extended to it.

1. Visual Identity

Element	Current Treatment	Design Rationale
Background	Warm kraft-paper texture, tan/beige tone throughout.	Reads as a personal notebook, not an institutional interface. Most screens this population interacts with day-to-day are clinical or institutional by necessity — this is a deliberate departure, and worth preserving rather than replacing with a cleaner but colder UI.
Primary CTA	Solid green buttons (Continue, Next, Skip Video), white bold text.	High contrast against the tan background for visibility. Green reads as "go/positive" without the alarm connotation red carries — appropriate given how much of this population's environment already uses red for restriction or warning.
Header bar	Dark charcoal bar, book icon, course/week title, numeric progress counter (e.g. "5/14").	Numeric progress (not a percentage or unlabeled bar) gives the learner a concrete, literal sense of how much remains — supports the predictability principle in the Instructional Strategy document.
Watermark	"Creative Writing" embossed at the bottom of content screens.	Subtle reinforcement of course identity without competing with foreground content for attention.

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Typography	Rounded, high-legibility sans-serif for body copy and buttons.	Prioritizes plain readability over stylistic personality — appropriate given the variable reading levels and possible corrective-lens limitations in this population.

2. Interaction Patterns

Accordion cards

One item expands at a time; expanding a new item doesn't force-collapse others unless the learner does so. Used for all definitional/reference content (Storytelling Elements, Conclusion). Keep this pattern exclusive to non-sequential content — don't use it for anything the learner must read in a specific order, since expand/collapse implies free choice of what to open.

Video

Revised standard, applied consistently to Screens 2, 7, and 10: Play on demand on, Auto play off, Auto progress off, skip button visible, prompt text framed as invitation ("Watch now, or skip when you're ready") rather than command. Any new video added to this or future modules should default to this configuration, not the original locked pattern.

Progress & navigation

Numeric counter, top right, on every screen except full-bleed video. Back/forward arrows where multi-part content exists (Screen 8's swipe-up cards). No hidden gestures without a visible tappable equivalent.

3. Content & Writing Style

Guideline	Applied Example
Second person, direct address	"Explore elements of style in writing" — not "Learners will explore..."
Plain language, no clinical/institutional phrasing	"Watch now, or skip when you're ready" instead of "Complete this module to demonstrate competency."
Invitations, not commands	Revised video prompt replaces "WATCH THE VIDEO TO CONTINUE" (all-caps command) with a lowercase, optional framing.
No assumed shared trauma or hardship	Character prompts avoid loaded terms like "broken home"; ask about internal motivation instead of biographical assumption — see Content Review Case Study, Case 5.
Target reading level: roughly 8th-9th grade	Applies to all instructional copy, not just content screens — button labels and system messages included.

4. What Not to Change

A few elements are working well specifically because of who this is for, and shouldn't be "modernized" toward a more generic e-learning look in future revisions. Each is included here as a deliberate instructional decision, not a style preference:

- The kraft-paper texture and warm palette — replacing it with a sleek corporate template would undercut the notebook-like, low-institutional feel that makes the module approachable.
- The numeric progress counter — don't replace with a percentage or unlabeled progress bar; the literal count is more concrete and easier to parse at a glance.
- The accordion pattern for reference content — don't convert to a forced linear scroll; the learner's ability to choose what to expand is a small but real instance of control worth protecting.